

(A) Mormon (Latter-Day Saints) Church

BRIEF INTRODUCTION

Mormon Church also (officially) known as 'The Church of Jesus Christ of Latter-day Saints (LDS-Church)', considered a Christian cult (not a branch or denomination) by majority of the Christians, with approximately 12 to 15 million (2015 estimates) members (often called Mormons) worldwide. Mormonism is founded by Joseph Smith (1805-1844) in 1830 CE in New York, USA.

Mormons believe (as claimed by Joseph Smith) that 'God the Father and Jesus Christ' visited **Joseph Smith (considered a modern-day prophet)** when he was about 15 years old (1820 CE), and told him all the existing Christian denominations of that time were wrong and forbade him to follow any of them. Three years later (in 1823) God sent angel Moroni to instruct him about his prophetic mission of restoring the Church.

Angel Moroni also told him about a buried book of golden plates (which contained the fullness of the gospel as delivered by the Savior-Jesus to ancient inhabitants of the American continent). Prophet Joseph Smith was eventually (in 1827 CE) ordered to unearth the buried plates and translate those into English which came to be known as 'The Book of Mormon'. A new restored church led by Joseph Smith by the name of 'Church of Christ' was formed in 1830 and eventually in 1938 the church was renamed 'The Church of Jesus Christ of Latter-day Saints'.

Mormons believe God through the ministering of angels (Moroni and John the Baptist) to prophet Joseph Smith, returned the priesthood authority to act in God's name to earth and thus restored (not reformed) the original church of Jesus Christ. The new formed church were getting converts from other Christians denominations and was meet with stiff resistance from the other denominations. Early Mormons moved from one place to another as violence and persecutions continued against them from the mainstream Christians. The cycle of violence continued and in 1844 Smith was killed by an angry mob in Illinois. After Smith's death, Brigham Young led the faithful to Salt Lake City, Utah, (Headquarter of the Mormon Church) and established the movement in firm footing.

Mormonism has grown ever since and has moved to other continents through missionary activities. Today vast majority (almost two-third) of Mormons live in United states and the rest are found mostly in Mexico, Brazil, Philippines, Chile, Argentina and Canada.

Mormonism is distinct from all other mainstream Christian denominations in many of its beliefs and practices; and is thus considered by majority of Christians as a cult in oppose to a branch or denomination.

PURPOSE OF LIFE

The purpose of life or as Mormons call it 'mortal life' (Mormons believe in 3 stages or parts of one's existence as premortal life, mortal life, and life after death) is to obtain physical bodies and have experiences that help people learn and grow; and be tested to see if they will obey God's commandants paving the way to become like God (Heavenly Father).The ultimate goal of 'mortal life' is to live with God, as God.

CONCEPT OF GOD

Mormons believe in one Godhead consists of three separate and distinct persons. God the Heavenly (or Eternal) Father; his Son, Jesus Christ; and the Holy Ghost are three members of the Godhead. They are one in perfect unity and harmony of purpose and doctrine.

They also believe God is an exalted, perfected man with a physical body like human. They believe man have the potential to become just like God hence giving the idea of more than one God. They also reject the mainstream Christian view of trinity or Trinitarian god.

God the Father: Also called Elohim and Havenly Father. Generally when the title God is used it refers to Him. Heavenly Father has a body of flesh and bones just like man but is immortal, perfected, and has a glory that words can't describe. God is perfect, all wise, merciful, kind, just, all-powerful and the ruler of the universe. God is not of another species nor is he the great unknowable one. He (along with Heavenly Mother are literally the Heavenly Parents) is literally (begotten) the Father of all male and female spirits. He is also the literal father of Jesus (spirit body and his physical body), His firstborn.

~~God the Father was once a man and lived on an earth like present day human beings. Over time he made himself perfect by following the commandments of his God and became a God himself.

~~Mormons are commanded to obey and give reverence to the Father alone and to pray to him in Jesus' name.

Jesus Christ: Jesus was known as Jehovah to the people of the Old Testament. Jesus is the first born literal (begotten) child (both in spirit and flesh) of God the Father. He is the second person of the Godhead and has tangible body of flesh and bone just like God the Father.

~~He works under the direction of the Father and is in complete harmony with him. All mankind are his literal brothers and sisters as he is the eldest of the spirit children of God the Father. Under the direction of the Heavenly Father, Jesus Christ created the heavens and earth (and everything on it).

~~He was during his earthly existence the literal, biological Son of God, and of Mary. He lived a sinless life following the commandments of God the father, set a perfect example of how all mankind should live; and made a perfect atonement for the sins of all mankind by shedding of his blood and giving his life on the cross. On the third day he rose from the dead, thus assuring the eventual resurrection of all mankind. Those who accept Jesus as their savior, repent of their sins and obey God's commandments can live eternally with Jesus and the Father.

~~Mormon's believe that after his resurrection, Jesus visited America, where he stayed for several days, teaching, healing and performed miracles.

~~All prayers, blessings, and priesthood ordinances should be done in his name for God's (God the Father) sake.

The Holy Ghost: Also called the Holy Spirit, the Spirit, and the Spirit of God. He is the third person of the Godhead and made of spirit alone, not having a body of flesh and bones. The Holy Ghost performs some important roles in the plan of salvation. He bears witness of the Father and the Son, reveals the truth of all things, sanctifies and guides those who have repented and become baptized.

SOURCES OF RELIGIOUS/SACRED INFORMATION

Sources and concept of religious information is one of the main differences between Mormons and other Christians. Mormons consider words, both written and spoken, by holy men of God when moved upon by the Holy Ghost, as sacred scripture. They also believe in continual revelation and 'open cannon', which means holy men (the Church leaders, mainly the President and the 12 current apostles of the church) continue to receive divine inspiration (instructions/revelation) and that their utterances either edit/update current canonical text or equal in authority to existing canonized texts.

The current official canonized scriptures of the Mormon Church consist of (1) the Bible, (2) Book of Mormon, (3) Doctrine and Covenants, and (4) Pearl of Great Price. Other than the Bible the rest of the canon constitutes revelation, inspiration, translation and exegesis spoken by prophet Joseph Smith. Mormons also consider official pronouncements and sermons by 'general authorities' of the Church as authoritative.

KEY FEATURES OF BELIEF

THE CHURCH AND ORGANIZATION

The LDS church is a hierarchical Church headquartered in Salt Lake city, Utah and led by the President (the longest serving Apostle) of the Church. Mormons believe under the direction of Jesus Christ, the Church is led by 15 apostles, who are also regarded as prophets, seers, and revelators. They along with other members of 'General Authorities' exercise both ecclesiastical and administrative leadership over the church and direct the efforts of regional leaders down to the local level. All members of the 'General Authorities' are men only.

Worldwide the Church is divided into different geographic areas. In local level larger congregations called wards are led by a bishop and two counselors. Smaller congregations called branches are led by a branch president and two counselors.

The local church structures called chapels (wards/branches) are usually simple, plain and interior is devoid of statues and images. They also have temples which are buildings dedicated to be the 'House of the Lord', and those are considered by Mormons to be the most sacred structures on earth; and only members in good standing are permitted entrance. Most LDS temples are identified by a gold-colored Angel Moroni statue on top of the temple.

THE CLERGY

LDS church (unlike other Christians Denominations) has no full time dedicated paid professional clergy, hence do not use the term clergy. Instead locally, unpaid and part-time priesthood holders lead the church. They refer to their Church officers as stake presidents, bishops or branch presidents. These individuals are laypersons who, without professional training in theology, are called to these positions for limited periods of time by those having authority. Centrally the worldwide Church is led by fulltime General Authorities, some of whom have lifetime tenure and some receive modest living allowances.

LDS church only ordains male into priesthood. Usually all faithful and worthy Mormon men age 12

and above may receive the priesthood. Worthy young men between ages 12 to 18 are ordained into Aaronic priesthood (the lesser priesthood) as deacons, teachers, or priests. Worthy adult men ages 18 and up may receive the Melchizedek (the higher or greater) Priesthood, as elder, high priest, patriarch, Seventy, and Apostle.

It is important for all Mormons to serve as missionaries to spread their faith within and outside their communities. All young Mormons (between ages 18 to 19) are strongly encouraged to leave home and serve as missionaries for 18 months to 2 years (fulltime, unpaid) outside their community or in a foreign country.

LDS church do not ordain women or homosexuals into priesthood.

MARY

Mormons believe Mary was a virgin chosen by God the Father to be the mother of His Son in the flesh. How the union (sexual or not) between God and Mary resulted into her becoming pregnant with God's literal son in flesh, is usually left alone or understood as a mystery of God. They reject the Roman Catholic traditions of the immaculate Conception, the perpetual virginity and assumption of Mary. They also do not worship or use her for intercessory prayer.

THE SAINTS

A faithful member of the LDS church is a saint hence all faithful members are saints. They do not have a special category or patron saints nor do they seek intercession from them.

THE ANGELS

LDS Church teaches that angels are also offspring of God. There are two kinds of angels in heaven: those who are spirits and those who have bodies of flesh and bone. Angels who are spirits either have not yet obtained a body of flesh and bone, or they are spirits who once had a mortal body and are awaiting resurrection. Angels who have bodies of flesh and bone have either been resurrected from the dead or translated. There are various types angels and they perform a variety of functions to implement the work of the Lord on the earth.

TRANSLATED BEINGS

LDS Church teaches of a unique class of beings, persons whom the Lord has "translated" or changed from a mortal state to a state in which they are temporarily not subject to death, and in which they experience neither pain nor sorrow. These beings appear to have much greater power than mortals. All translated beings will eventually experience physical death and resurrection. This state is a necessary condition in special circumstances to further the work of the Lord.

SATAN AND DEVILS

Lucifer (as satan was then called) was the spirit brother of Jesus, born as a spirit after Jesus "in the morning of pre-existence", literally a spirit son of God. In the pre-mortal existence Lucifer was an angel in authority in the presence of God. In the pre-mortal existence, God the Father convened a "Council in Heaven" in which He offered the plan of righteousness to help His children become as He is. But needed a Savior, Jesus (who was then called Jehovah) responded willingly to give His life to pay for sins of all humanity and teach them how to return to the Heavenly Father. But Lucifer came with an alternate plan in which he will force mankind to follow god's will (no freedom of choice) and thus save and exalt all. And in return he wanted the Father's honor and glory given to him personally.

Lucifer's plan was rejected by God. Lucifer became angry and he rebelled, a third of the spirits followed him in rebellion. After rebellion he and his followers fought a war in heaven against Jesus and his followers. God cast out Lucifer and his followers from heaven to earth, where he became Satan and they all became devils. They were denied the opportunity of obtaining mortal bodies and experiencing mortal life, and will be eternally damned. Since then Satan has sought constantly to deceive all men and women and lead them away from the work of God.

ORDINANCES (SACRAMENTS)

Mormons prefer the term ordinances, which are sacred ceremonies that has spiritual meaning. God has established these unchangeable, eternal ordinances as essential elements of the Plan of Salvation and redemption.

Some ordinances (called saving ordinances) are necessary for salvation (baptism and gift of the Holy Ghost) and for exaltation (priesthood ordination, temple Endowment, celestial marriage and sealings).

Other ordinances (called non-saving ordinances) enhance the physical, emotional, and spiritual welfare of the recipient; such as Sacrament/Lord's Supper, administering to the sick, naming of children, confirmation, consecration of oil, dedication of buildings, and dedication of graves etc. The ordinance of Sacrament (known as Lord's supper, Eucharist or communion by other Christian denominations), most frequently performed public Mormon ritual, in which participants meet together often (usually weekly) to partake of the bread and water (instead of wine) in remembrance of the Lord Jesus. This ordinance is designed to renew the covenants that Mormons made during baptism to obey God's commandments and to remember the sacrifice of Christ.

Baptism is performed to worthy individuals of age 8 and over and is done by complete water immersion. The bread and water used during ordinance of sacrament (Lord's supper) are symbols of Jesus' flesh and blood.

Ordinances are performed by worthy men and boys who have been given the authority of the priesthood.

Vicarious ordinance: An ordinance performed by a living person on behalf of someone who is dead. Mormons believe that individuals who die without the knowledge of true gospel must be provided with an opportunity to accept those teachings in the afterlife. So faithful Mormons search

out the genealogical records of their ancestors and perform by proxy all of the required saving ordinances. These ordinances take effect only when those (dead physically but are in spirit world) for whom the ordinances were performed accept them.

WORSHIP AND PRAYER

All worship is directed to Heavenly Father in the name of Jesus Christ. True and perfect worship consists in following in the steps of the Son of God; it consists in keeping the commandments and obeying the will of the Heavenly Father.

~~Ritual worship includes prayer, fasting, church service, participating in gospel ordinances, and other practices that show devotion and love for the Father.

~~Mormons focus their worship in weekly Sunday meetings that include sermons, the sacrament (Lord's supper) and classes on scripture and LDS history.

~~One Sabbath day (Sunday) each month is set aside for the purpose of fasting. During this time Mormons go without food and water for twenty-four hours. They then contribute the many saved from fasting to the Church (for welfare program) which is called a fast offering.

~~Mormons are required to give a tenth part of a person's annual income to the Church.

SIN

Sin is to willfully disobey God's commandments or to fail to act righteously having knowledge of the truth. Sin results in the withdrawal of the Holy Ghost which makes one unable to dwell in the presence of Heavenly Father. Through the atonement of Jesus Christ, one can repent and be forgiven of his or her sins.

~~Mormons do not believe in the concept of 'original sin' (a key difference with mainstream Christianity).

Repentance is through Faith in Our Heavenly Father and Jesus Christ; feeling sorrow for sin; confession to and seeking forgiveness from Heavenly Father; abandonment of sin; restitution as much as possible; and righteous living.

~~Serious transgressions (such as violations of the law of chastity) may jeopardize a person's membership in the Mormon Church. Such sins need to be confessed to both the Father and His priesthood representatives in the Church.

SALVATION

Mormon concept of Salvation is different and unique compared to all other Christian denominations. Mormon concept of salvation is to be saved from both physical and spiritual death; and to live forever as a family in the highest heaven of the celestial kingdom. There are various levels of salvation because there are various levels of belief and works among people.

~~Salvation is attained through faith in the atonement of Jesus Christ, baptism; and following the ordinances and commandments of God throughout the entire life.

ESCHATOLOGY

Death: Mormons believe at death (end of mortal existence) physical body and spirit separates, spirits will go to the spirit world to wait for the resurrection, while the body remains in the grave. They believe each person suffers only one physical death since once resurrected, bodies can die no more.

~~**In the spirit world** spirits will have the same form (shape) as when they lived on the earth with bodies of flesh and bones. Immediately after death the disembodied righteous spirits will go to paradise and the rest will go to spirit prison.

Paradise is the temporary abode for the righteous spirits where people (spirits) are happy, peaceful, free from trouble, sorrow, and pain. There they wait for the resurrection of the body. There they can teach others (those in spirit prison) about the gospel or learn more about it themselves.

Spirit prison (also known as temporary hell) is the temporary abode for the rest of the spirits (wicked, disbeliever, unaware of the gospel) where they will be tormented by guilt, weeping, wailing and restlessness. There they have the opportunity to accept the gospel and repent be resurrected at Jesus' second coming.

Second Coming of Jesus: When Jesus comes again from heaven, at the beginning of the Millennial Era, the wicked people will be removed from the earth and the righteous will be caught up in a cloud while the earth is cleansed. The righteous dead (those in paradise and those who accepted the gospel and repented in spirit prison) will be resurrected .

Millennium is a thousand year rule by Jesus, only the living righteous (including good people that are not member of the Church) and resurrected righteous will live on earth. There will be peace and righteousness for those thousand years and Satan will no longer have power over the people. The living righteous who will get old and die (the first death) will be instantly resurrected to immortality. Near the end of the Millennium, Satan will begin to have power again and some people will follow him. There will be a war between the two parties and Satan will be defeated forever.

Resurrection is reuniting the spirit body with the physical body of flesh and bones from the grave. All will have the same physical body as before but immortal and perfected. All people will not be resurrected at the same time nor will to the same glory (perfection). Many were resurrected at the time of Christ's resurrection called first resurrection. Resurrection than started again at Christ's second coming and will continue till the end of the Millennium. The unrepentant sinners; and those people who served Satan and was against God (called sons of Perdition) will come forth in the last resurrection.

Final (Last) Judgment will take place after the last resurrection. Everyone will be brought before God the Father and He will judge everyone through Jesus Christ. People will be judged by Jesus according to their actions and obedience to God's commands and will be awarded either the celestial kingdom, the terrestrial kingdom, the telestial kingdom, or outer darkness.

The Celestial Kingdom, highest of the three kingdom, is the place where the Heavenly Father and Jesus live. Most righteous Mormons will live there. Some Mormons there will live in the highest part of the celestial kingdom is called 'exaltation' or eternal life. To live in this part of the celestial kingdom, they (in their mortal life) must have been married in the temple and must have kept the sacred promises they made in the temple. They will receive everything that God the Father has and will become like Him. They will be able to have spirit children and make new worlds for them to live on, and do all the things God the Father has done.

The Terrestrial Kingdom, second of the three kingdom, is not as wonderful as the celestial

kingdom. Neither God the Father nor Jesus live there but they will get visits from Jesus. They will not live with God the Father and nor will have all He has. Less righteous Mormons and people who weren't Mormons on earth but became (after death) one later in the spirit prison.

The Telestial Kingdom, lowest of the three kingdom, less wonderful than terrestrial kingdom. God the Father and Jesus do not live or visit that kingdom. Instead angels will visit and people will have the influence of the Holy Ghost. Wicked people (liars, thieves, murderers, false prophets, adulterers etc.) who didn't accept the teaching of Jesus on earth or in spirit prison will end up there.

Outer Darkness (Hell), is where Satan, devils (spirits that followed him) and those people on earth who followed and served Satan and were against God. They will live there forever in darkness, sorrow, and suffering.

STATUES AND IMAGES

Mormons do not use pictures or statues in the chapel, the place congregational of worship. Images and statues are allowed in other parts of the church building. Also they do not use cross or crucifix like other Christian denominations.

DIETARY RESTRICTIONS

LDS church forbids consumption of alcohol, tobacco and hot drinks such as tea and coffee.

SEXUAL MORALITY

LDS Church teaches that moral sexuality is between a man and a woman, within a valid marriage only.

Sexual immorality include adultery, fornication, homosexuality, incest, or any other unholy, unnatural, or impure sexual activity.

CONTRACEPTION

LDS Church let the decisions about birth control and the consequences of those decisions rest solely with each married couple. But the church prohibits elective abortion as a method of birth control.

ABORTION

Abortion is only allowed in extreme circumstances such as rape, incest, and when life of mother or the fetus is threatened.

DIVORCE AND REMARRIAGE

Marriage is between a man and a woman only; performed under the law of the gospel and the holy priesthood, is for mortal life and for eternity (if sealed in the temple). Polygyny (having multiple wives) was allowed and practiced widely up until 1890 CE, when a revelation through then church president Wilford Woodruff terminated the practice.

Divorce is discouraged but allowed. Remarriage after divorce (and cancellation of sealing in case of woman seeking remarriage) is allowed.

FOR MORE INFORMATION (Some Sources Used For This Article)

<https://www.lds.org/scriptures/gs?lang=eng&letter=s>
https://www.lds.org/manual/gospel-principles?lang=eng&_r=1
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